Red in cultures and traditions

Red does not have the same **meaning** everywhere. In some places it is the colour of luck and celebration, elsewhere of protection, faith, physicality or strength. And then there are traditional systems that work with red in yet another way – as an element, a symbol or a tool for balance.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. What red means in different cultures and how traditional systems work with it.

Red in different cultures

China

In China red is the colour of **luck**, **joy**, **prosperity** and **celebration**. That is why you will see it at weddings, at Chinese New Year and at important family events.

For centuries red has been linked with a good omen and wishes of success. At New Year red envelopes with money – hong bao – are given, and lanterns and red inscriptions with wishes for the coming year are hung up.

Red also plays a prominent role at weddings, where it symbolises joy, happiness and a new beginning. Interestingly, while white tends to be the wedding colour here, in traditional Chinese symbolism **white** is on the contrary associated more with **mourning and funerals**.

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India

In many parts of India red is strongly linked with **weddings**, **marriage**, **femininity** and **an auspicious beginning**. That is why traditional wedding garments are often red, crimson or red and gold.

In Hindu symbolism red is linked with **life force**, **fertility**, **love** and the energy of **shakti** – the feminine principle of power and creative energy.

Married women may also wear sindoor, a red powder applied in the parting of the hair. The red powder kumkum is used in religious ceremonies too and may be applied to the forehead as a sign of blessing, respect or an auspicious event.

In India red is therefore often much more than just "the colour of passion". It can mean **life**, **protection**, **union**, **feminine strength** and **sacredness**.

And as elsewhere, India is **not one tradition** in one package – meanings and customs differ by region, religion and family.

Russia

Here red is interesting already in the language itself. The Russian word krasny now means "red", but in older Russian it also meant "**beautiful**".

This is also where the name of Red Square in Moscow is explained from – it was originally not meant to be "red" in a political sense, but rather a beautiful or magnificent square.

Language sometimes keeps older layers of meaning far longer than our idea of a colour. Here **beauty and red** once overlapped.

Later, of course, red in Russia also gained a strong political layer, but that came much later.

It is a nice example of how **one colour** can carry completely **different stories** in different times.

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Christianity

In the Christian tradition red is the colour of **fire**, **blood**, **sacrifice** and strong **faith**.

In the liturgy it is used, for example, at Pentecost, where it recalls the fire of the Holy Spirit. Red also appears at feasts of martyrs, where it refers to blood and sacrifice.

Cardinals wear red robes as a symbol of readiness to bear their faith even at the cost of their own blood.

Red here stands between two strong images. **Fire and blood**. Fire can mean **zeal**, **strength** and **spiritual energy**. Blood means **life**, **sacrifice** and a willingness to really carry something.

That is why in a Christian setting red is both **festive** and **serious**. It is not a gentle background colour. **It always says that something important is happening**.

Red in traditional systems

Each tradition looks at red **a little differently**, but all of them take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and inspiration, not a guide to healing.

Traditional Chinese medicine

Traditional Chinese medicine works with five elements – wood, fire, earth, metal and water. Red belongs to **fire**. It is linked with summer, the south, the bitter taste, joy and the sphere of the heart.

The “heart” here is not just a pump. In the traditional view it is also linked with **shen**, a concept translated roughly as **mind**, **spirit** or **consciousness**. It covers joy, sleep and contact with others. When, according to this teaching, there is too much fire, restlessness, overheating and poor sleep are described. When there is too little, they speak of cold and tiredness. Wood feeds fire like logs in a stove, and from the ashes comes earth.

> Fire is meant to warm you. It is not meant to set your living room on fire.

What you can take from it. In this system red is **the colour of fire**, that is, of warmth, joy and connection with people. **You do not have to** analyse the state of your heart with every red jumper. A simple question is enough. **How much warmth, joy and closeness do I have in my life right now?** And how much is already heat, pressure and rush?

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Ask yourself

“Where does the fire burn pleasantly in my life – and where is it already too hot?”

A spark that sweeps others along

In traditional images fire is linked with a person who **can inspire others**. You get an idea, you light up, and ten minutes later there is a WhatsApp group and someone is looking for an extension cord. That is the lovely side of fire. But it has the same speed in the other direction too. You say “sure” before you have even looked at your calendar. In the image of fire there is a difference between “I burn for something” and “everything burns me”. **You do not have to** brake your energy, it just does not need to run at maximum revs all the time.

I love red. Why?

Perhaps you are drawn to its decisiveness, or you feel more like yourself in a red jumper. Perhaps after a long period of duties the wish to want something for yourself is coming back. And perhaps you simply like it, which is a perfectly legitimate reason. If you do not want to show the feeling to anyone, a ring or a small detail can carry it. Sometimes it is enough that only you know.

I am afraid of red, or I cannot stand it. Why?

Sometimes it is **not red itself that bothers us** but everything **we carry with it**. Blood, prohibition, shouting, pressure or moments when we were far too exposed. And at other times you are simply tired and in the evening a crimson throw is shouting at you from the sofa. **You do not have to force yourself** into a red dress just because red is often linked with courage. The point is **to notice what it does to you** and to respect your own “yes” and “no”. And sometimes the best colour therapy is simply **to put that throw away in the wardrobe**.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of “energy”, the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are chosen to balance whatever there is too much of. Opposites are treated with opposites. Red belongs to fire; it is warm, active and stimulating. Some people come alive in it, to others it feels like one more voice in the room that they really did not need.

How this relates to the colour red. According to some sources, red is read in Ayurveda as the colour of fire and movement. **That is why it suits places where there is too much cold and heaviness, and fits less well where there is already enough fire.**

Pitta

This is how a woman who is purposeful, quick and thorough, and easily flares up, is described. Because pitta already belongs to fire, a strong red can heat it up even more. **Pitta does not need another match. Rather a little space around the fire.**

- **Red in moderation**
  Brick, coral or powder pink, only as an accent.
- **Add some cool**
  Blue, green and white. A white shirt and one red scarf instead of a whole red outfit.

Vata

This is how a woman who is imaginative and quick, but restless and often cold, is described. With red the recommendations diverge. Sometimes the warmth heats pleasantly, at other times it is too sharp. **If the colour calms you, keep it. If it winds you up even more, take it away.**

- **Softer and deeper shades**
  A blanket, jumper or tablecloth.
- **Evening and sleep**
  For the bedroom rather warm, muted shades and calmer light.

Kapha

This is how a woman who is calm, stable and patient, but sometimes does not feel like getting moving, is described. **Red can give her warmth, energy and a small “okay, let's go”.** Not because it magically lifts you off the sofa.

- **Add red**
  A scarf, a cushion, lipstick, tomatoes and peppers on the table.
- **Add movement**
  A walk, dancing, a brisker pace.

When you need a spark

Sometimes you do not feel like going out, being with people or doing anything. A red detail can work as **a small signal**. Today I will join in with life a little. You do not have to head out right away in a scarlet dress. Sometimes **a raspberry scarf**, red **earrings** or **lipstick** is enough.

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When you are already running at full speed

If you are rushing and everything irritates you, red **may not do you good**. In the language of Ayurveda you would say **turn down the heat**. Try a smaller area, a more muted shade, or swap red for blue or green for a while.

An online test cannot reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. A colour will tell you nothing about the state of your health. It is not treatment.

A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols with two layers. **Personal** – that is, what we have experienced with a particular colour – and wider, culturally repeated images that return across eras and stories. In other words. Red can have a shared cultural tinge, but your own experience still has the last word.

- With him red is linked with blood, fire, passion and love. In one lecture he assigns it to feeling, that is, to how we evaluate experiences with the heart.
- It is often read as the colour of instinct, emotion and action, that is, of what happens before we have time to think it through.
- In alchemy, to which Jung referred a great deal, red is the final stage of transformation. It is read as completion.

What matters is that Jung **did not want to turn colours into a dictionary** of the “red means X” kind. The same red can be love for one woman, danger for another and a memory of grandmother's handbag for a third. So we always return to the question. What does it mean **for you**? A symbol without a personal story is only half a sentence.

Ask yourself

“What do I refuse to feel or show in myself?”

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Feng shui

In feng shui red belongs to fire – that is, to warmth, activity, visibility and yang energy. Its counterpart is yin, which is linked more with calm and rest.

Fire is traditionally tied to summer, noon and the south. On the bagua map the southern part of a space is linked with fame, recognition and how visible we are to the outside world.

And red has yet another layer in Chinese culture. It is the colour of **luck**, **celebration** and **good beginnings**. That is why we find it at weddings, at New Year and on red envelopes with money.

So yes – one colour can handle a wedding, success and a proper dose of attention.

Red is like chilli

> A little wakes the appetite, but a whole bag ruins your dinner.

In feng shui red therefore often works best as **an accent**. A cushion, a painting, a vase, a scarf or a detail on a textile can give a space a spark. A whole red wall, a red carpet and red curtains all at once can feel more like a room that refuses to lower its voice.

Especially in a space where you want to rest, this holds.

Red yes, but **it does not have to shout** from all four walls.

Simple tips

- **Want more energy?**
  Add one striking red element.
- **Want more calm?**
  Choose brick, wine, rusty or red only in a detail.
- **Is it already too much?**
  Add wood, linen, cream, brown, muted green or more empty space.
- **Want more courage?**
  Start with a small red detail that you carry with you. A scarf, a bracelet or a pouch in your bag.

And above all. Before you repaint the whole room, try a throw, a fabric or a larger colour sample. It is cheaper than a third round of painting and far fewer swear words.

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What people say and what holds true

MYTH Red makes a bull furious.

TRUTH Bulls do not distinguish red the way we do. What enrages them is the movement of the cloth, not its colour. The red muleta is more tradition than biology.

MYTH Red brings luck and love.

TRUTH In the Chinese tradition red is the colour of celebration and luck, but in feng shui the amount is watched. A large red surface in a bedroom can unsettle more than calm. Schools differ on this.

MYTH Red is always aggressive.

TRUTH It depends on the shade and the area. Brick, wine or poppy tones feel earthy and warm. One red detail is a good start, a whole wall calls for some thought.

Fire is not just red

In feng shui fire is not recognised by colour alone. It also includes **light**, **flame**, **sun**, sharp and **triangular shapes**.

So a room can be “fiery” even without a single red wall.

A striking lamp, harsh light, geometric patterns and a few strong colours already do their part. If you long for calm in the evening, a new cushion sometimes does not help. Sometimes it is easier to turn off the lamp that shines like an interrogation.

What red goes well with

- **Cream, linen, cotton, light wood**
  Red stands out, but enough calm remains around it.
- **Terracotta, clay and brown**
  More warmth, less drama. Red softens and feels more earthy.
- **Muted green and plants**
  Next to brick or wine it looks natural. Just watch out for sharp green and sharp red side by side – that can become visual ping-pong.
- **Black and metal**
  They give red drama and elegance. Great for one striking corner. Less great if you want the whole room to whisper “rest”.

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Elements

In feng shui the elements are related to one another.

- **Wood feeds fire**
  A plant and a red picture can feel alive and growing.
- **Fire creates earth**
  Terracotta, clay and brown tones calm and ground red.
- **Water dampens fire**
  Symbolically this includes black and very dark blue.
- **Fire acts on metal**
  Red with brass can feel festive, with grey more restrained.

Take it as a **traditional image** of the relations between elements, **not as a ban** on combining two colours in one room.

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Feng shui room by room

What works – what to watch for – a simple tip.

Living room

What works. A red cushion, blanket, vase or picture. Even **one stronger wall** is fine if the rest of the space stays calmer.

What to watch for. A red sofa, red curtains and a red carpet all at once can make the room seem **to want something all the time**.

I am not saying the sofa is to blame for the quarrel. But if nobody at home can slow down, it is worth looking around you too.

A simple tip. One striking piece and let the rest breathe. Wood, linen and matt surfaces calm red nicely.

Kitchen and dining room

What works. Red ceramics, napkins, one chair, a terracotta tile or a small accent.

What to watch for. The kitchen already has its fire – the hob and the oven. If you add red walls, a glossy red worktop and harsh light, you are figuratively putting more logs on.

A simple tip. Put red where you want **liveliness** and **a social atmosphere**, but keep large areas calmer.

Bedroom

What works. Muted red, **wine**, **brick** or a smaller accent in textiles. A cushion, blanket, pyjamas, nightdress or a small picture.

What to watch for. A bedroom is for **sleep** and **closeness**. But when red is on the walls, curtains and carpet, and chaos all around on top of that, your head works a double shift.

Red and clutter together can work like **two alarm clocks at once**.

A simple tip. Keep red near the body or in one detail and keep large areas calmer.

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Children's room

What works. Red on toys, a cushion, a small rug or small accessories.

What to watch for. A child usually has enough energy without help from the interior. If the whole room is striking and the child cannot wind down in the evening, it may be good to take some of the red away.

We really do not need to turn an ordinarily lively child into a monkey on an elastic band 24/7.

A simple tip. Large areas calm, strong colours rather in things that can be moved.

Study and studio

What works. In a studio a red picture or detail can bring courage and energy.

What to watch for. If you read, calculate or work at a computer for several hours, **a large red area** right in front of your eyes can be more of a distraction.

A simple tip. Red **next to the workspace** yes. The whole room in a state of "DEADLINE!" is not necessary.

Hallway and bathroom

What works. In the hallway a smaller red picture or a brick-coloured bench. In the bathroom a wine-coloured towel, terracotta ceramics or a red bath mat.

What to watch for. A narrow dark corridor can take less red than a light open space.

A simple tip. Ask yourself. Does the space **welcome me**, or does something **shout** at me right after I arrive?

A question for you

"Where does it do you good and where does it already disturb you?"

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